OpenClaw Complete Tutorial: From Beginner to Intermediate

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What is OpenClaw

OpenClaw (formerly ClawdBot/Moltbot) is the hottest open-source AI Agent project in 2026, with over 68,000 stars on GitHub. It's not just a chatbot — it's a personal AI assistant that can actually execute tasks.

Key Features

Local Execution Your data stays on your device, no cloud upload needed. Full control over privacy and data security.

Real Execution Not just conversation — it can actually operate your computer. Automate email, calendar, file management, and more.

Multi-Platform Messaging Supports WhatsApp, Telegram, Discord, Slack, and 10+ platforms. Manage all communications from a single entry point.

Persistent Memory Maintains context and user preferences across sessions. Gets to know you better over time, continuously improving efficiency.

Open Source & Free Completely open source, just need your own API key. Free, with full self-control.

OpenClaw vs Traditional AI Assistants

Traditional AI (like ChatGPT): - You: "Help me organize my desktop files" - AI: "I suggest you do this: 1. Create folders… 2. Sort by type…"

OpenClaw: - You: "Help me organize my desktop files" - OpenClaw: "Done! I organized 47 files into 5 folders by type."

This is the fundamental difference between a “chatbot” and an “AI Agent.”

Beginner Phase: Basic Setup

Step 1: Environment Preparation

System Requirements

- **Operating System**: macOS, Linux, or Windows (WSL required)
- **Node.js**: v18 or higher
- **AI Model API Key**: Claude or GPT API key

🔨 Practice Task 1: Check Your Environment

```
# Check Node.js version
node --version

# If version is below v18, you need to upgrade
# macOS/Linux: use nvm
nvm install 18
nvm use 18

# Windows: visit nodejs.org to download and install
```

✅ **Completion Criteria**: Terminal shows Node.js version >= v18.0.0

Step 2: Install OpenClaw

Method 1: NPM Installation (Recommended for Beginners)

```
# Install OpenClaw globally
npm install -g openclaw

# Verify installation
openclaw --version
```

Method 2: Docker Installation (For Docker Users)

```
# Pull the image
docker pull openclaw/openclaw:latest

# Run the container
docker run -d --name openclaw \
  -v ~/.openclaw:/root/.openclaw \
  openclaw/openclaw:latest
```

Method 3: Source Installation (For Developers)

```
# Clone the project
git clone https://github.com/openclaw/openclaw.git
cd openclaw

# Install dependencies
npm install

# Start
npm run start
```

🔨 Practice Task 2: Complete Installation

Choose one installation method and complete the OpenClaw installation.

✅ **Completion Criteria**: Running `openclaw --version` or `openclaw --help` displays information normally

---

Step 3: Initial Configuration

Run the Setup Wizard

```
# Start the initialization wizard
openclaw onboard
```

The wizard will guide you through: 1. Choose AI model provider (Anthropic Claude / OpenAI GPT / Local models) 2. Enter API Key 3. Choose messaging platform (Telegram / Discord / WhatsApp, etc.) 4. Configure system permissions (sandbox mode recommended for starters)

Configure API Key

If you don't have an API Key yet, you can get one from:

- **Anthropic Claude**: anthropic.com (recommended, $20/month Pro subscription)
- **OpenAI GPT**: platform.openai.com
- **API Aggregation Services**: apiyi.com (supports multiple models, new users get free credits)

🔨 Practice Task 3: Complete Initialization

Run `openclaw onboard` and complete all configuration steps.

✅ **Completion Criteria**: - Successfully configured API Key - Selected at least one messaging platform - Completed permission settings (sandbox mode recommended)

Step 4: First Conversation

Start OpenClaw

```
# Start OpenClaw
openclaw

# Or start Dashboard (Web interface)
openclaw dashboard
```

Connect Messaging Platform — Telegram Example

1. Search for `@BotFather` in Telegram
2. Send `/newbot` to create a new bot
3. Get the Bot Token
4. Configure in OpenClaw:

```
openclaw config set channels.telegram.botToken "YOUR_BOT_TOKEN"
openclaw config set channels.telegram.enabled true
```

5. Search for your bot in Telegram and start a conversation

🔨 Practice Task 4: First Conversation

Chat with your OpenClaw assistant for the first time and test these commands:

```
Hello, introduce yourself

What can you do for me?

What time is it now?
```

✅ **Completion Criteria**: The bot can reply to your messages normally

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Step 5: Understand Core Concepts

Gateway

Gateway is how OpenClaw interacts with the outside world:

- **Message Gateway**: Telegram, Discord, WhatsApp
- **API Gateway**: HTTP API interface
- **CLI Gateway**: Command-line interaction

Skills

Skills are OpenClaw's capability extensions, similar to "plugins" or "apps":

- Each Skill defines a set of specific tasks
- You can install third-party Skills from Clawhub
- You can also write custom Skills yourself

Memory

OpenClaw remembers: - Your preferences and habits - Previous conversation context - Important information and tasks

Sandbox

Sandbox mode restricts OpenClaw's system access permissions to protect your computer:

- **Sandbox Mode**: Restricts file system, network, and shell access
- **Full Access Mode**: Full permissions (use with caution)

🔨 Practice Task 5: Explore the Workspace

```
# View OpenClaw's working directory
ls ~/.openclaw

# View configuration file
openclaw config list

# View installed Skills
openclaw skills list

# Run security audit
openclaw security audit
```

✅ **Completion Criteria**: Understand OpenClaw's file structure and basic configuration

---

Intermediate Phase: Practical Skills

Step 6: Install and Use Skills

Browse Skills Marketplace

Visit Clawhub or use the command:

```
# Search Skills
openclaw skills search email

# View Skill details
openclaw skills info @author/skill-name
```

Install Common Skills

```
# Install email management Skill
openclaw skills install @openclaw/email-manager

# Install calendar management Skill
openclaw skills install @openclaw/calendar

# Install file organizer Skill
```

```
openclaw skills install @openclaw/file-organizer

# Install web search Skill (using Tavily instead of Brave)
openclaw skills install @openclaw/tavily-search
```

🔨 **Practice Task 6: Install and Test Skills**

- Install at least 3 Skills
- Test each Skill's functionality
- Record which Skills are most useful to you

✅ **Completion Criteria**: Successfully installed and used at least 3 Skills

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Step 7: Google Workspace Integration

OpenClaw can manage your Gmail, Google Calendar, Google Docs, and more.

Configuration Steps

1. **Create Google Cloud Project** Visit console.cloud.google.com, create a new project, enable Gmail API, Google Calendar API, Google Drive API

2. **Create Service Account** In IAM & Admin → Service Accounts, create a service account, download the JSON key file

3. **Configure OpenClaw**

```
openclaw config set integrations.google.enabled true
openclaw config set integrations.google.credentialsPath
        "/path/to/credentials.json"
```

4. **Authorize Access**

```
openclaw integrations google authorize
```

🔨 **Practice Task 7: Google Integration Practice**

Complete these tasks:

1. **Calendar Management**: Have OpenClaw create a meeting invitation for you

```
Create a meeting for tomorrow at 3pm, 1 hour long, topic "Project
Review"
```

2. **Email Processing**: Have OpenClaw check unread emails

```
Check my unread emails and summarize the most important 3
```

3. **Document Editing**: Create a Google Doc

```
Create a new Google Doc titled "Weekly Report Template" with this
week's work summary framework
```

✅ **Completion Criteria**: Successfully complete at least 2 Google Workspace tasks

---

Step 8: Set Up Scheduled Tasks (Cron Jobs)

OpenClaw can execute tasks automatically on a schedule.

Create Daily Brief

```
I want you to send me a brief every morning at 8am, containing:
1. Today's weather
2. My calendar schedule
3. Number of unread emails
4. An inspirational quote
```

OpenClaw will automatically create a cron job.

View Scheduled Tasks

```
# List all scheduled tasks
openclaw cron list

# View task details
openclaw cron show <task-id>

# Disable a task
openclaw cron disable <task-id>

# Delete a task
openclaw cron delete <task-id>
```

🔨 Practice Task 8: Create Scheduled Tasks

Create the following scheduled tasks:

- **Daily Brief**: Send weather and schedule every morning
- **Weekly Summary**: Send weekly statistics every Friday afternoon
- **Timed Reminder**: Remind you to end work at 6pm every day

✅ **Completion Criteria**: Create at least 2 scheduled tasks and verify they run normally

---

Step 9: Configure Persistent Memory

OpenClaw's memory system allows it to remember your preferences.

Train Your Assistant

Tell OpenClaw about yourself:

```
Remember the following about me:
- My name is [your name]
- My job is [your profession]
- My working hours are Monday to Friday 9:00-18:00
- I prefer concise replies, not too wordy
```

```
- I communicate in Chinese
- My timezone is GMT+8
```

View Memory

```
# View memory file
cat ~/.openclaw/memory/long-term.json

# Or ask in conversation
What do you remember about me?
```

🔨 **Practice Task 9: Personalize Your Assistant**

- Give your assistant a name
- Tell it your basic information and preferences
- Set your work habits and schedule
- Test if it remembers this information

✅ **Completion Criteria**: OpenClaw demonstrates understanding of you in conversation

---

Advanced Phase: Advanced Applications

Step 10: Write Custom Skills

Skills are defined using YAML or Markdown format.

Basic Skill Structure

Create file `~/.openclaw/skills/my-first-skill.yaml`:

```yaml
name: "Daily News Summary"
description: "Get and summarize today's tech news"
version: "1.0.0"

triggers:
  - "daily news"
  - "tech news"

steps:
  - action: web_search
    query: "latest tech news today"
    max_results: 5
  - action: summarize
    content: "{{search_results}}"
    style: "bullet_points"
  - action: respond
    message: "📰 Today's Tech News Summary: {{summary}}"
```

Install Custom Skill

```
# Reload Skills
openclaw skills reload

# Test Skill
openclaw skills test "Daily News Summary"
```

🔨 **Practice Task 10: Create Custom Skill**

Create a custom Skill that implements one of the following:

- **Weather Assistant**: Query and format weather for a specified city
- **Task Manager**: Add, view, and complete to-do items
- **Website Monitor**: Regularly check if a website is accessible
- **Price Tracker**: Monitor price changes for a product

✅ **Completion Criteria**: Successfully create and run a custom Skill

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Step 11: Multi-Agent Management

You can run multiple OpenClaw instances, each with different configurations and use cases.

Create Multiple Agents

```
# Create work Agent
openclaw create-agent work
openclaw config --agent work set ai.model "claude-sonnet-4.6"

# Create personal Agent
openclaw create-agent personal
openclaw config --agent personal set ai.model "gpt-5.3"

# Switch Agent
openclaw switch-agent work
openclaw switch-agent personal

# List all Agents
openclaw list-agents
```

Use Cases

- **Work Agent**: Connect company email, project management tools
- **Personal Agent**: Manage personal schedule, family affairs
- **Experiment Agent**: Test new features, new Skills

🔨 **Practice Task 11: Configure Multi-Agent**

Create at least 2 Agents for different purposes and configure different:

- AI models
- Messaging platforms

- Skills
- Permission levels

✅ **Completion Criteria**: Can switch between different Agents and use them

---

Step 12: Docker Sandbox Security Practices

Docker sandbox provides the strongest security isolation.

Configure Docker Sandbox

```
# Install Docker (if not already)
# macOS: Download Docker Desktop
# Linux: sudo apt install docker.io

# Configure OpenClaw to use Docker sandbox
openclaw config set sandbox.mode "docker"
openclaw config set sandbox.docker.image "openclaw/sandbox:latest"

# Test sandbox
openclaw sandbox test
```

Sandbox Limits

Docker sandbox restricts: - File system access (can only access specified directories) - Network access (configurable whitelist) - System command execution - Resource usage (CPU, memory limits)

🔨 Practice Task 12: Security Configuration

- Enable Docker sandbox mode
- Run security audit: `openclaw security audit --deep`
- Fix security issues based on audit results
- Test if sandbox restrictions are effective

✅ **Completion Criteria**: Security audit passes, sandbox works normally

---

Step 13: Browser Control

OpenClaw can control the browser to perform complex web operations.

Enable Browser Control

```
# Install browser control plugin
openclaw plugins install @openclaw/browser-control

# Configure browser
openclaw config set browser.enabled true
openclaw config set browser.headless false  # false means show browser
        window
```

Usage Examples

```
Open browser, visit GitHub, search "openclaw", and tell me the top 3
results

Help me search "mechanical keyboard" on Amazon, find the top 3
highest-rated products, and record the prices
```

🔨 Practice Task 13: Browser Automation

Complete these tasks using browser control:

- **Information Collection**: Scrape data from a website and organize it
- **Form Filling**: Automatically fill out an online form
- **Price Comparison**: Compare prices for the same product across multiple websites

✅ **Completion Criteria**: Successfully complete at least 1 browser automation task

---

Step 14: Integrate with Other Tools

Linear Integration (Project Management)

```
# Install Linear Skill
openclaw skills install @openclaw/linear

# Configure API Key
openclaw config set integrations.linear.apiKey "YOUR_LINEAR_API_KEY"
```

Usage example:

```
Create a new task in Linear: "Fix login page bug", high priority
```

Obsidian Integration (Notes)

```
# Install Obsidian Skill
openclaw skills install @openclaw/obsidian

# Configure Obsidian vault path
openclaw config set integrations.obsidian.vaultPath
        "/path/to/obsidian/vault"
```

Usage example:

```
Create a new note in Obsidian titled "OpenClaw Learning Notes"
```

🔨 Practice Task 14: Integrate Third-Party Tools

Choose at least 2 tools you commonly use and integrate them with OpenClaw:

- **Project Management**: Linear, Jira, Trello
- **Notes**: Obsidian, Notion, Evernote
- **Code**: GitHub, GitLab
- **Communication**: Slack, Discord, Teams

- **Others**: Based on your needs

✅ **Completion Criteria**: Successfully integrate and use at least 2 third-party tools

---

Step 15: Advanced Configuration Optimization

Performance Optimization

```
# Configure cache
openclaw config set cache.enabled true
openclaw config set cache.ttl 3600

# Configure concurrent requests
openclaw config set ai.maxConcurrentRequests 3

# Configure timeout
openclaw config set ai.timeout 30000
```

Cost Control

```
# Set daily API call limit
openclaw config set ai.dailyLimit 1000

# Set monthly budget (USD)
openclaw config set ai.monthlyBudget 50

# View usage statistics
openclaw stats usage
openclaw stats cost
```

Logging and Debugging

```
# Enable detailed logging
openclaw config set logging.level "debug"

# View logs
openclaw logs

# View logs for specific time
openclaw logs --since "2026-02-20"

# Export logs
openclaw logs --export logs.txt
```

🔨 Practice Task 15: Optimize Configuration

- Optimize performance configuration based on your usage
- Set cost control to avoid unexpected high fees
- Configure logging for easier problem debugging
- Monitor usage and cost for a week

✅ **Completion Criteria**: - Configured cost control - Can view usage statistics - Understand logging system

---

Step 16: Use ClawLite Installer Instead of Manual Setup

If you've read this far and thought "this is a lot of steps" — you're not alone.

OpenClaw is powerful, but the setup curve is real. In this step, use the **ClawLite installer** to replace the manual setup flow from Steps 1-15.

What is the ClawLite Installer?

The ClawLite installer is an Electron-based installer for OpenClaw. It installs OpenClaw itself, but removes most manual setup friction.

- **Electron installer**: Desktop installer flow built with Electron.
- **Installs OpenClaw itself**: You are still running OpenClaw after install.
- **Cross-platform support**: Supports Windows and macOS.
- **One binary, fast setup**: Download, run, done. No complex manual bootstrap steps.
- **BYOK (Bring Your Own Key)**: Use your own API keys. Pay your provider directly.

When to Use OpenClaw Manual Setup vs ClawLite Installer

	OpenClaw (Manual)	ClawLite Installer
Setup time	30-60 minutes	60 seconds
Customization	Unlimited	High (with guardrails)
Target user	Developers, tinkerers	Everyone else
Self-hosted	Yes	Yes
Open source	Yes	Core engine is OpenClaw
Price	Free (BYOK)	Free tier + paid plans

Get Started

1. Visit clawlite.ai
2. Select your operating system
3. Click the install button

That's it. No terminal commands, no dependencies, no config files.

Or visit clawlite.ai to learn more.

🔨 Practice Task 16: Try the ClawLite Installer

If you found any part of Steps 1-15 frustrating, try the same workflow with the ClawLite installer and compare the experience.

✅ **Completion Criteria**: Running OpenClaw with messaging platform connected — in under 2 minutes.

Practice Task Checklist

Beginner Phase (Required)

- [ ] Task 1: Check and install Node.js v18+
- [ ] Task 2: Complete OpenClaw installation (choose one method)
- [ ] Task 3: Run initialization wizard, configure API Key
- [ ] Task 4: Complete first conversation with OpenClaw
- [ ] Task 5: Explore workspace and configuration files

Intermediate Phase (Recommended)

- [ ] Task 6: Install and test at least 3 Skills
- [ ] Task 7: Complete Google Workspace integration (at least 2 features)
- [ ] Task 8: Create at least 2 scheduled tasks
- [ ] Task 9: Personalize your assistant, configure memory system

Advanced Phase

- [ ] Task 10: Create a custom Skill
- [ ] Task 11: Configure multiple Agents for different scenarios
- [ ] Task 12: Enable Docker sandbox and pass security audit
- [ ] Task 13: Complete one browser automation task
- [ ] Task 14: Integrate at least 2 third-party tools
- [ ] Task 15: Optimize configuration and set cost control
- [ ] Task 16: Try ClawLite installer and compare the experience

Real-World Projects (Challenge)

- **Project 1**: Build an automated workflow that sends personalized briefs every morning
- **Project 2**: Create an automatic email classification and response system
- **Project 3**: Build a multi-channel message aggregation center
- **Project 4**: Develop a price monitoring and alerting system
- **Project 5**: Build an automated content publishing system (blog/social media)

FAQ

Q1: What are the technical requirements for OpenClaw?

OpenClaw is primarily aimed at users with some technical background. You need to:

- Know how to use the command line
- Understand environment variable configuration
- Know the concept of API Key

But the installation process has been greatly simplified. As long as you can run npm commands, you can use OpenClaw.

Q2: How to manage security risks?

Key security recommendations:

- **Use Sandbox Mode**: Use sandbox mode during initial testing
- **Don't Store Sensitive Passwords**: Don't store plaintext passwords in configuration files
- **Regular Review**: Regularly review automation rules
- **Understand Permissions**: Only enable permissions you need
- **Dedicated Device**: Recommended to run on a dedicated device (like Mac Mini, old laptop)
- **Separate Accounts**: Create separate email and accounts for OpenClaw

Q3: What are the approximate API costs?

Depends on usage intensity:

- **Light Use** (10-20 conversations/day): ~$5-10/month
- **Medium Use** (50-100 conversations/day + scheduled tasks): ~$20-30/month
- **Heavy Use** (heavy automation + browser control): ~$50-100/month

Money-saving tips: - Use API aggregation services for better pricing - Set daily/monthly usage limits - Prefer cheaper models - New users typically get free credits

Q4: Can I use local models?

Yes! OpenClaw supports connecting to local models via Ollama:

```
# Install Ollama
curl -fsSL https://ollama.ai/install.sh | sh

# Download model
ollama pull llama3.2

# Configure OpenClaw
openclaw config set providers.ollama.enabled true
openclaw config set providers.ollama.baseUrl "http://localhost:11434"
openclaw config set providers.ollama.model "llama3.2"
```

Learning Resources

- **Official Documentation**: docs.openclaw.ai
- **GitHub Repository**: github.com/openclaw/openclaw
- **Discord Community**: discord.com/invite/clawd
- **Skills Marketplace**: clawhub.com

Tutorial by @stark_nico99 Translated for English audience